

A Cold Day

Appalachia, 1864

By the time I left the mines I was cold and hungry. These winter days I always felt cold and hungry. I'd left my good jacket at the entrance and put it on before making my way back to town.

There was something in the air that day. The howling of the wind. The way the tree limbs bowed too low for the little dust of snow which covered them that day. I didn't mind. Just so long as I could get home and find a nice warm meal.

The winter forest contained no memory of life. Nothing skittered up trees, there were no tracks in the snow, nor dove-tailed deer. At the edge of the forest, I found the river frozen and followed it back to the village. An eerie quiet permeated the small mining town but the smell of smoke told me there was life yet.

"Gwendolyn!" I yelled as I knocked on the first cabin I came across. "Where is everyone?! I know it's damn cold out but the world ain't froze over now has it?"

"That you Greg? Whatchu you doin' outside? Ain't you hear what they? They seen a shadow in the woods movin' without its master. It's the sign of a creature, they say. Now you better get inside real quick like, iffen you got any sense." She called through the door.

"You been listenin' to them damn Indians again, ain't cha?" I said to her. "I'm damn near freezing out here Gwen, why don't you let me warm up by your fire real quick and I'll dispel them ghost stories they've been telling you?"

"I ain't takin' no chances Greg. Especially, not for you. Don't come back here no more, Greg. You won't find any more warmth from me."

I dragged my hand down the wooden door. The snow was piling up around me, freezing me to the bone.

"Damn bitch." I whispered, I could feel an anger. A distant rage. But even that provided no warmth. So I shuffled off along the streets...

"CASSIDY!" I said, banging on a new door. "Cassidy, you got to let me in!" I could hear her shuffling behind the door.

"Greg...? That you?" She whispered.

"Course it is!" I said. "I'm cold and hungry, you see what it's like out here? Now let me in!"

"Greg... Why ain'tcha home with Lizzie? Didn't you hear them warnings? Algonquins been sayin' the forest smells rotten. That it's got an unnatural silence to it. And ain'tcha noticed this cold? I don't know much about that 'Wendigo' they say they huntin', but something ain't right. You gotta getch yourself home!"

"Cassidy, I can smell that stew you cookin' in there. Now I'm so cold I'm damn near brittle, won't you just sneak me a little bowl real quick through the door?" I said to her, my head against the door once again. I could hear her breathing on the other side.

"Is that Greg?" A new voice came, the voice of a man, John. "Cassidy, what are you waiting for? Let him in, and fetch us a stiff drink, why don't ya?" he said, the voice was coming from a little ways, as if from the second floor.

"Now Cassidy, do as your husband tells you." I says "Just a little alcohol like ol' times would warm me up real quick." I said to her.

"Greg." It was John's voice again. "I'm right here." His voice came from right behind the door, next to Cassidy's. "And that ain't me." he said.

"This ain't the time for joking, John. You pick whatever bottle you want and I promise I'll pay for it." I said through the door.

"You know I quit drinkin' weeks ago. And I don't got anything strong enough to warm you up, Greg." John said.

"What's the harm in one drink on an occasion as rare as this one? Don't you miss it, John?" I said to him.

"Unfortunately, I miss it every damn day." He said in a stern voice. "But I don't miss you, Greg." He said.

I chuckled to myself.

"And I thought it was cold out here!" I said to him.

"It sure is," he replied. "Now go home, Greg."

"Maybe I will." I replied, spitting. The saliva froze to a crystal before it hit the ground.

Smoke billowed from my house, telling me she was still home. I grasped my hand around the metal handle breaking the frost which coated it. The metal only grew colder with my touch and a bolt prevented the door from opening.

"Honey, I'm home!" I says through the door.

"Greg, honey? Is that you?" She said.

"Course it's me, Lizzie! Why you got this bolt in my way?"

"Greg, I told you not to go out this morning! Why'd you have to go?" She said sobbing through the door.

"The early bird gets the worm, Lizzie! Ain't you ever heard of that? There's money in them mines! Now why won't you let me in, it's damn cold out here!" I yelled.

"Honey, it ain't just cold out. It's negative twenty degrees."

"All the more reason to let me in, darling." I said to her, my breath freezing against the wood of the door.

"Greg. They already told me. The tribe said they saw the river freeze as you approached. You can't be alive. And you ain't Greg no more." Lizzie said, she was still crying behind that door. I was crying too. But the tear froze before it could roll down my cheek.

"Let me in, Lizzie." I said. "Stop with this Indian horseshit and let me in!" I banged on the door.

"Tell me, Greg." She said, no longer sobbing. "Did you go to Gwen's house first on your way back?"

"Let me in, Lizzie."

"I bet you did, didn't you? But you didn't find any warmth there either, did you, Greg?"

"Elizabeth!" I screamed, my voice coming from all around. I grabbed the handle and shook it, freezing the metal in my hand.

"You work in a coal mine and still never found anything to warm you." She said.

"I'm hungry and freezing, and dyin', Elizabeth!"

"I tried to keep you warm, honey." She said, "Lord knows I tried!"

"ELIZABETH!" I said, rattlin' the door, freezing the wood.

"That's right." She sniffled, before growing serious. "Say my name." I heard the sound of a chair drag across the floor. "Cause I ain't keeping yours."

"LET ME IN!!" I screamed, pounding my frozen flesh against the door. The smoke of the chimney thickened as I froze the air around her cabin, grey flakes of charcoal raining back down and landing on my pale, emaciated flesh.

"Greg." It was Lizzie's voice again. "You better get used to screamin'..." She said before I heard her tilting the chair against the door.

"Cause they comin' for you... And I don't think you'll ever be warm again."